the forest. There were a couple of temples in the woods, and the villagers used to do puja once or twice a year. While we told the first group that there could be no more tree-cutting, we allowed the second group access to the temple for the puja. We would have to schedule the tests in such a way that there is no activity during the puja days, which was a small compromise we had to make to earn the goodwill of the local population.

And we got enough of it. By the entrance to the property, on the Tirunelveli side was a village called Panakudi. The MLA there, a man named Yusuf, helped us get local support. The project site was on the northeastern side of the tail end of the Western Ghats, and within the 3 km buffer radius of the proposed principal test stand stood Sivakamipuram, a village of barely fifteen families. The villagers were more than friendly. They received us with garlands and were willing to part with their land. These were poor families who were happy with what the government was offering them as compensation.

But the owner of a twenty-acre plot by the road to the project site refused to vacate. We learned that it belonged to someone close to a Congress MP. There were a few structures on the plot, and a board outside announced itself as 'Haldane Coconut Research Centre'. It was a complete farce, as nowhere in the vicinity was a coconut palm. We were convinced that the owner's intention was to hold on to the piece of land till its value peaks after the ISRO facility comes up.

This piece of land was not in the middle of our project site, but when everyone along the road to the test complex had vacated, I didn't want this one to be an exception. Moreover, if we planned an expansion later, it would prove an impediment. I told Seshan this. After a few days, Seshan got back to me, and his response surprised me.

'Leave them alone,' he said.

I have known Seshan as a relentless fighter. Here there was no illegality on the part of the land owner, but Seshan didn't want to upset someone even if it was to further the interests of ISRO and the Government of India.

Another local heavyweight who tried to stay put in the test complex vicinity was not as lucky. Kurien, a Keralite who held some fifty acres on